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Dusting 'em OFF

BY ZIPP NEWMAN, Sports editor emeritus

They came into the Southern League the same year — 1947. Charlie Hurth succeeded Billy Evans as president. Eddie Glennon succeeded Paul Florence as Business Manager of the Birmingham Barons.

Charlie Hurth was as friendly as an old shoe. He was efficient, an immaculate dresser and a good story teller. He reigned over ten of the most prosperous years of the Southern League. The first two were fabulous, the only two years of more than two million in attendance. The league stayed in the million and over attendance through 1967.



NEWMAN

Eddie Glennon full of life, fun and compassion for the poor, was certainly one of Birmingham's most unforgetable characters. He injected as much life in the Barons, he saw the attendance at Rickwood jump from 157,928 to 323,309 his first year.

Under the popular Fred Walters the Barons set the all-time league record for attendance with 445,926 in 1948.

From 1947 through 1958, the Barons played to 3,147,295 in regular season play. They drew 63,416 for the play-offs, All-Star and Dixie Series games.

Twice Glennon was named the outstanding business manager of the minor leagues.

EDDIE GLENNON spun Irish stories by the hundreds. He directed his Scot stories at the Ole Duster, wanting to know if the Newmans could match the Glennons? He was told to read the teachings of John Cardinal Newman.

Glennon loved football. He had played pro-football in a league with Lou Little, Columbus University coach. He would come up to the press-box at Rickwood field beaming, looking like the cat that ate the canary, pointing down to the box-seats back of the Barons' dugout at Frank Thomas, Hank Crisp, Red Drew, Shug Jordan or Paul Bryant. Then we would get into the hottest arguments about his knowledge of the playing personnel at Alabama and Auburn.

It was a wonderful era of football in Alabama. Red Drew coached three bowl teams but his best team, they wouldn't let play in the Orange bowl. No one had more to say over Shug Jordan's Auburn's Tigers winning the 1957 National title than Eddie. Then came Paul Bryant with three National championship teams.

For jesting from the floor, the Monday Morning Quarterback Club's meetings were never the same after Glennon left.

Glennon's voice could be heard over Rickwood as he rode the umpires' for missing plays. Yet the umpires never had a better friend and the ball players he kidded, would come by the office after games and hold admtration feasts.

I wish I had a recording of all of Eddie's joshing with Charlie Hurth, Larry Gilbert, Earl Mann, Fresco Thompson, Andy Cohen, Joe Engle, Dixie Walker and Harry Walker. He sold Earl Mann on hiring Dixie and Dixie won a pennant his first year with Atlanta.

You felt like Eddie didn't like you if he didn't needle you.

Now the two who came into the Southern League together are gone, departing with in a year of each other.

I hope there's in the future a Major League franchise and another Eddie Glennon for Birmingham.

THE BIRMINGHAM Touchdown Club had a great party with Coach Joe Paterno of the Penn State's Orange Bowl winners headlining the show. Congrats to Doug Layton and his cohorts.

Pepper Rodgers, the losing coach in the Orange, will headline the annual Birmingham Monday Morning Quarterback Club's jubilee, Jan. 15. It was the top year for the QB's in raising funds except for the year money was asked to build The Crippled Children's Clinic and Hospital. Glenn Ireland was a wonderful Captain and leader.

The inaugural enshrinement dinner of the Alabama Sports Hall of Fame comes up Feb. 7 in the Municipal Auditorium. Chairman Frank House has more celbs coming than has ever attended a sports dinner in the state to help induct Johnny Mack Brown, Paul Bryant, Mike Donahue, Jimmy Hitchcock, Don Hutson, Shug Jordan, Joe Louis and Frank Thomas.

There are no more tickets.

One of football's greatest coaches of college and pro-football, will be the headline speaker Feb. 15 at the Gadsden Quarterback Club. Clark Shaughnessy was a master play maker. After his Stanford team won the National championship and the Rose Bowl game against Biff Jones' Nebraska, the colleges embraced the T formation.

Alabama should always feel grateful to Clark Shaughnessy. After Tulane turned the Rose Bowl bid down, Shaughnessy insisted Alabama would make a great opponent for Washington and Wildcat Wilson, and they did, putting the Rose back in business.